

1915 ▶ 1920

1915 CONTINENTAL DRIFT

In 1915, German geophysicist Alfred Wegener published his theory of how the continents were once joined together, but gradually moved apart over millions of years. Wegener used as proof the fact that the same fossils and similar rock formations could be found in both Africa and South America. His theory was not fully accepted until more was known about Earth's crust (surface) and how it is made up of large plates (see p.211).

Continents form a single landmass or "supercontinent"



250 million years ago

Gap begins to form between South America and Africa



130 million years ago

Atlantic Ocean now lies between South America and Africa

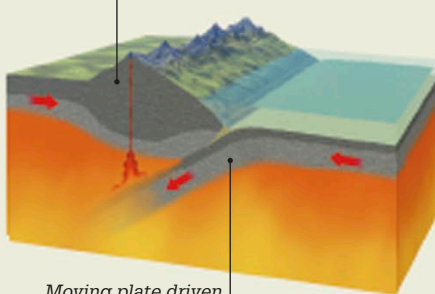


Present day

Moving continents

Around 300 million years ago, all the continents formed one supercontinent called Pangea. Around 200 million years ago, they began separating, carried by the movement of Earth's plates. The continents are still moving—North America and Eurasia move apart by 1 in (2.5 cm) each year.

Surface of plate driven upward to form mountain range



Moving plate driven below its neighbor

Birth of mountains

Alfred Wegener's theory proposed that many mountains formed through the thrusting together of parts of the moving continents, causing them to buckle and fold. Previously, people thought that mountains formed through the cooling and wrinkling of Earth's surface hundreds of millions of years ago.

The Himalayas, in Asia, began forming 40–50 million years ago.



1915

A star discovery

Working in a South African observatory, Scottish astronomer Robert Innes discovered the star Proxima Centauri. At a distance of 4.25 light years or 25 trillion miles (40 trillion km), it is the nearest star to Earth after the Sun.



Proxima Centauri as seen by the Hubble Space Telescope

1915

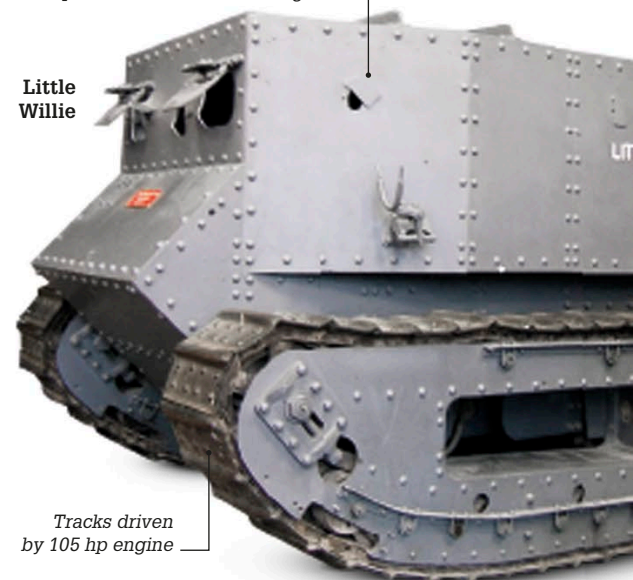
1915

Little Willie

The first prototype tank, called Little Willie, was produced in the UK. It could cross 5-ft- (1.6-m-) wide trenches on its tracks, albeit at a slow top speed of just 2 mph (3.2 km/h). This tank paved the way for the Mark 1, the first tank to serve in battle the following year.

0.2-in- (6-mm-) thick steel body protects crew of 4–6 from gunfire.

Little Willie



Tracks driven by 105 hp engine